

The Best Places to Eat Cataplana

Don Sebastião expensive

Don Sebastião is a welcoming restaurant on a central cobbled street in the western resort of Lagos, whose owner believes that for *cataplana*, simple is best. His enduringly popular *amêijoas na cataplana* (clam *cataplana*) is presented in the traditional copper vessel and sticks firmly to the basics: small local clams cooked with tomato, onion, garlic, peppers, and a splash of white wine, with *presunto* (smoked ham) and *chouriço* (garlic sausage) added for body and flavor. The *chouriço*, incidentally, makes an early appearance in any meal at Don Sebastião, served as a hot, sliced, and flaming appetizer, doused in *medronho*, a local firewater made from the fruits of the strawberry tree (which taste rather like lychees). You can eat outside on the cobbles, which is the best way to get a flavor of lively Lagos, though there's a warm, rustic interior too, as well as a rather fine underground *adega* (wine cellar), which the waiters can usually be persuaded to show off at the end of a meal.

Rua 25 de Abril 20–22, Lagos; open noon–10 PM daily; www.restaurantedonsebastiao.com

Also on the Algarve

In Lagos, dine on the rooftop terrace of the **Estrêla do Mar** (+351 282 769 250; *moderate*). The restaurant couldn't be better placed for the ingredients for a *cataplana* – it's right on top of the fish market. In Tavira, the stunning **Pousada de Tavira** (www.pousadas.pt; *expensive*), a boutique hotel fashioned from a 16th-century convent, has an excellent restaurant that puts a contemporary twist on regional dishes like the *cataplana*.

Also in Portugal

Many of Lisbon's inhabitants escape to the nearby coast at the small fishing port and resort of Ericeira, where the unpretentious **Mar à Vista** (+351 261 862 928; *moderate*) is the best place for *cataplana*. Farther north, the Atlantic-facing resorts of Nazaré and Figueira da Foz are both traditional summer boltholes for Portuguese families, with lots of great seafood restaurants. Try Figueira's renowned shellfish specialist, **Caçarola II** (www.cacaroladois.com; *expensive*), which serves a fish, shrimp, and clam *cataplana*.

Around the World

Outside Portugal it's rare to find a genuine *cataplana*, cooked in the traditional copper utensil, but London's oldest Portuguese restaurant, **O Fado** (www.ofado.co.uk; *expensive*), prepares a monkfish-and-mussels version in the correct manner.



Above Charcoal-grilled seafood, from sardines to lobsters, is a feature of life in the Algarve, and its tempting smell wafts along the coast

Left The two-handed copper *cataplana* has a hinged lid and seals completely, retaining all the flavorsome juices of the ingredients